

AI Reading Dialogue: Instructions

ISS 2440: Introduction to Philosophy, Politics, Economics, and Law · Fall 2026

Four times this term you read the week's required reading *with an AI chatbot open* (any major one: Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, ...). As you read, ask the model questions about the text as well as follow up questions. The point is not to have the AI summarize the reading for you. Instead, it is to practice asking sharp, well-informed questions and to interrogate the answers. You are graded on *your* side of the conversation only.

The reading

Choose one (or both) of the required readings of the week the dialogue is due.

Dialogue 1	Fri Sep 18	Hobbes, <i>Leviathan</i> , ch. 13 or Locke, <i>Second Treatise</i> , chs. 2–3 (or both)
Dialogue 2	Fri Oct 16	Tocqueville, “Tyranny of the Majority” (<i>Democracy in America</i> , Vol. I, ch. 15)
Dialogue 3	Fri Oct 30	Marx, <i>Wage Labour and Capital</i>
Dialogue 4	Fri Nov 13	Hayek, “The Use of Knowledge in Society”

How to do it

1. Open the chatbot and upload the reading.
2. Read. Whenever a passage puzzles you, provokes you, or reminds you of something, stop and ask. Performance will improve if you quote the passage.
3. You are encouraged to follow up until the answer is clear, convincing, or shown to be wrong.
4. When you are done, tell the AI: “*Export our entire conversation, word for word, as a Markdown (.md) document.*” Download the file, open it, and check that it contains the whole exchange — your questions and its answers, nothing shortened. That file is what you send me.

Non-comprehensive suggestions for asking questions

- **Ask as you read, not after.** Questions that arise mid-text, tied to a specific sentence or example, are worth far more than questions about the whole text at the end.
- **Iterate.** Ask *why*, *what is the evidence of [X]*, *Is [X] a counterexample*, *is that really what the author says because...?* Three good follow-ups on one point beat ten unrelated questions. You can also ask about the author, its other works, etc. if relevant.
- **Connect.** You can link the text to something from this course (Sowell’s two visions, Alchian on property rights, the Prisoner’s Dilemma, ...) or from another class, and ask the model whether the link holds. Be precise.
- **Chase the details.** If the reading makes you think of an example (historical, empirical, current) but you are unsure of the facts, ask for the details and the evidence, then ask whether the example really fits the author’s argument.
- **Push back.** Raise an objection and see whether the model (and the author) can answer it. When the model is wrong, vague, or unsupported, say so and say why.
- **Do not outsource.** Never ask “summarize this” or “what are the main points?” Simple questions are fine; questions you could have asked without opening the book are not.

What to submit, when, and where

- **What:** the **Markdown (.md) file** the AI exported for you (step 4 above) — the full conversation. If your chatbot cannot produce a file, paste its Markdown export into a text file and send that.
- **Where:** by email to louisrouanetecon@gmail.com — *not* my UFL address, *not* Canvas. Subject line: ISS 2440 – AI Dialogue N – Last name, First name.
- **When:** by **11:59 pm on the due date** in the table above. Late dialogues are not accepted; your lowest of the four is dropped, so the three highest count, each an equal share of the 10%.

How it is graded

Each dialogue is scored on four criteria of equal weight. Generic prompts (e.g. “summarize this”) and transcripts that show no evidence of having read the text receive low marks regardless of length.

Close reading	Questions and comments refer to specific passages, arguments, or examples in the text. I will be looking for clear evidence the reading was done.
Quality of questioning	Questions are sharp, build on one another, and push beyond surface summary toward the argument’s assumptions, mechanisms, and implications.
Critical evaluation	You test the model’s answers (spotting errors, vague or unsupported claims, and gaps, if any) and explain why.
Connections	You link the reading to course concepts, other readings, other classes, or real-world cases, and pin down the details of those links.